ERA 19

The Affluent Society

1945 – 1960

The boom · suburbs · mass culture · conformity

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

How did postwar prosperity reshape American life—and who was left out?

KEY TERMS

The GI Bill · the baby boom · suburbanization · television · rock 'n' roll · the Other America

ALIGNED TO

CED Topic 8.4–8.5 · AMSCO Ch. 8.4–8.5

PROSPERITY AND ITS PRICE

The Affluent Society

The Postwar Boom



- The economy soared—the GNP nearly doubled between 1945 and 1960.
- The **GI Bill** sent veterans to college and helped them buy homes.
- Pent-up demand unleashed a wave of **consumer culture**.

The Baby Boom

- Returning veterans and prosperity sparked a **baby boom**.
- The U.S. population grew by nearly 30% in the 1950s.
- Demand exploded for homes, schools, toys, and family goods.



The Suburban Frontier



- Mass-produced developments like **Levittown** made homeownership affordable.
- The **Interstate Highway Act** (1956) tied suburbs to cities—and boosted car culture.
- Millions moved from cities to the **suburbs** and the **Sun Belt**.

The Television Age

- By 1960, most American homes had a **television**.
- TV created a shared national **consumer culture**.
- Advertising and family sitcoms shaped how Americans saw themselves.



SECTION

Conformity & Its Critics

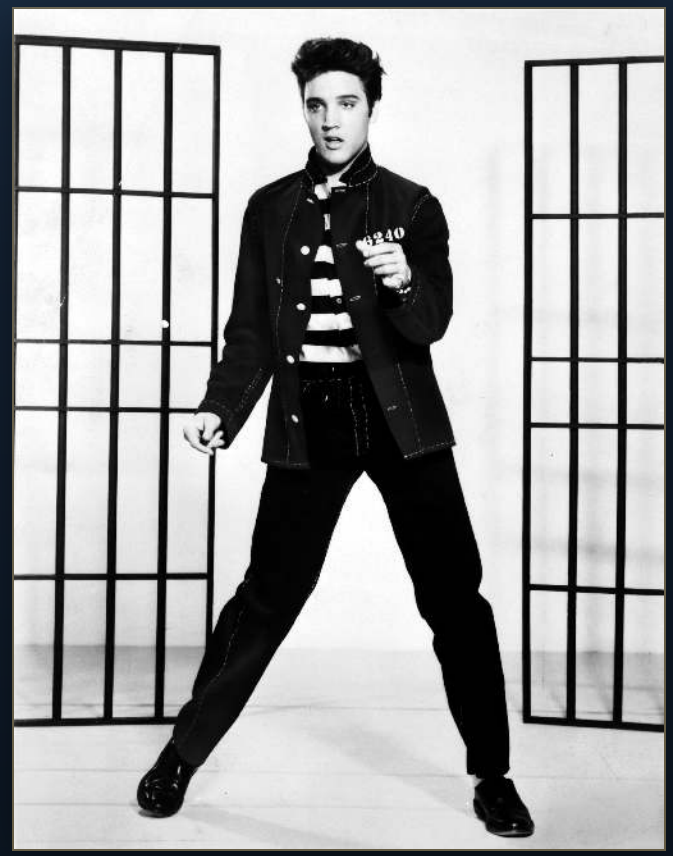
The Age of Conformity



- White-collar work and suburban life prized fitting in—the '**organization man**.'
- A cultural ideal pushed women back into the home.
- A religious revival reinforced the emphasis on **conformity**.

Rock 'n' Roll & the Beats

- **Rock and roll**—led by **Elvis Presley**—gave rise to a rebellious **youth culture**.
- The **Beats**, like **Jack Kerouac**, rejected middle-class values.
- Beneath the calm surface, a generation began to question **conformity**.



The 'Other America'

I

Poverty Amid Plenty

Millions—especially in cities and rural areas—remained poor.

II

Shut Out of the Suburbs

Redlining kept most Black families out of the new suburbs.

III

The Invisible Poor

Prosperity hid an '**Other America**' that the boom left behind.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

The Affluent Society

1. The **GI Bill**, the **baby boom**, and consumer demand powered a postwar boom of **suburbs** and **television**.
2. A culture of **conformity** faced early challenges from **rock 'n' roll** and the **Beats**.
3. Prosperity was uneven—**redlining** and poverty left an '**Other America**' behind.

DISCUSS & APPLY

The Affluent Society

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

CAUSATION

Explain how **government policy** and **consumer demand** fueled the postwar boom.

COMPARISON

Compare the ideal of 1950s **conformity** with its **critics**.

CONTINUITY & CHANGE

Who was excluded from the '**affluent society**,' and why?

Up next — **Class 55: The Civil Rights Movement** (Brown to Birmingham)